

UDL for Little Learners

Before You Read This Book

Jeff Horwitz · Foreword by Katie Novak · Wiley / Jossey-Bass, December 2026

How to use this One statement per chapter. Check where you are right now -- honestly, not aspirationally. When you are done, look at where your Not Yet boxes cluster. Use the guide on page 2 to find your starting point.

Chapter	In my classroom, right now...	Not Yet	Sometimes	Consistently
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PART ONE -- BACKGROUND

What Is UDL?	I understand the difference between UDL and differentiation, and why it matters specifically for early childhood.	☐	☐	☐
Designing the Environment	My classroom is set up so students can navigate it independently, without asking me where things are.	☐	☐	☐
Community & Connections	I have intentional structures that help every student feel like a member of this classroom, not a guest.	☐	☐	☐

PART TWO -- EMBEDDED PRACTICES

Transitions	My transitions have been explicitly taught -- students know the signal, the expectation, and what to do when they arrive.	☐	☐	☐
Reflection	I build regular time for students to reflect on their learning, with supports in place for students who are not yet verbal.	☐	☐	☐
Small Group Instruction	When I pull a small group, the rest of my students are productively independent without needing redirection from me.	☐	☐	☐
Emotional Literacy	I have a calm corner or regulation space that students know how to use on their own -- it is a tool, not a timeout.	☐	☐	☐
Centers	My centers have multiple entry points -- a student who is early in their learning and one further along can both engage meaningfully.	☐	☐	☐

PART THREE -- FROM THE DAY

Arrival & Morning Routines	Morning arrival is predictable and immediately purposeful -- students know exactly what to do from the moment they walk in.	☐	☐	☐
Morning Meeting	Every student has a genuine role in morning meeting -- no one disappears into the background.	☐	☐	☐
Calendar	Students do the thinking during calendar time -- it is not something I lead while they watch.	☐	☐	☐
Phonics & Reading	My foundational reading instruction offers multiple ways to practice -- not everyone at the same pace in the same way.	☐	☐	☐
Writing	Students have a buffet of writing tools and scaffolds -- available to all, required of none.	☐	☐	☐
Recess	Recess in my school is intentionally designed -- students with social, physical, or sensory needs have real access to it.	☐	☐	☐

Math	Math in my room offers flexible entry points -- students are not all solving the same problem in the same way.	☐	☐	☐
Read Aloud / Whole Group	Students respond in multiple ways during read aloud -- not just raising their hand to answer a question.	☐	☐	☐
Closing Circle & Dismissal	The end of my day is as intentional as the beginning -- students leave reflected, connected, and regulated.	☐	☐	☐

When you're done → flip to page 2

Where to Start

Look at where your Not Yet boxes clustered. Find your pattern below.

If your Not Yet boxes cluster in...	Open the book here first	One move before you even read
Part One UDL, Environment, Community	Read Part One front to back. It is the foundation everything else rests on. Without it, the daily strategies are harder to sustain.	<i>Add image labels to five containers in your room this week. Watch how quickly students stop asking where things are.</i>
Part Two Transitions, Reflection, Small Group, Emotional Literacy, Centers	Pick the embedded practice that disrupts your day most. Go to that chapter first. The others will still be there.	<i>Choose one transition. Teach it like a lesson -- what it looks like, what it sounds like, what students do when they arrive.</i>
Part Three The daily routines	Go straight to the chapter for the part of the day that is most on your mind. The book was designed to be read this way.	<i>Replace one hand-raise moment today with a think-pair-share. Notice who shows up differently.</i>
Spread across all three parts	Start with Environment and Community. Those two chapters create the conditions that make everything else possible.	<i>Set up a writing tool buffet. Put out choices -- pencils, markers, paper types. Do not assign them. See what students reach for.</i>
Mostly Consistently across the board	Go straight to Where to Go From Here and the Reflection chapter. You are building, not starting. The book will still surprise you.	<i>Find one teacher in your building doing something you have not tried. Ask if you can watch.</i>

Before you start reading, write one thing down.

Which student are you most thinking about right now? What part of the day is hardest for them?

Three things to remember as you read

The book does not need to be read cover to cover. Go to the chapter that is most on your mind.

Variability is the rule, not the exception. You are not starting from zero -- you are making what you already do more intentional.

Start small. Pick one thing. Get it running. Let success breed success.



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